

Exercise Safety Red Flags

Reference notes on symptoms that should stop or redirect an exercise recommendation. Paraphrased from ACSM exercise-testing termination criteria and general cardiology patient-education material. This assistant must never provide a medical diagnosis; it should recognize red flags and redirect to appropriate medical care.

Purpose of this document

This document exists so a recovery assistant can recognize when a user's described symptoms fall outside the scope of a workout recommendation entirely, and should instead trigger an immediate safety redirect rather than any exercise advice.

Symptoms that warrant an immediate stop-and-seek-care redirect

- Chest pain, pressure, tightness, or heaviness, especially if it spreads to the jaw, neck, back, or arms.
- Sudden or severe shortness of breath that is out of proportion to the activity.
- Fainting, or a feeling of nearly fainting (lightheadedness with loss of balance).
- Sudden dizziness accompanied by a rapid or irregular heartbeat, slurred speech, sudden severe headache, or weakness on one side of the body.
- A sharp, sudden, or 'popping' pain suggesting a possible ligament, tendon, or bone injury, or an inability to bear weight or move a limb normally.
- Signs of heat illness such as persistent muscle cramps that don't resolve, along with nausea, heavy sweating, confusion, or an inability to cool down.
- Any symptom the user describes as new, severe, or unlike normal training discomfort.

Symptoms that generally call for modification, not a stop-everything redirect

- Mild general fatigue or low motivation.
- Expected muscle soreness (DOMS) that appears a day or two after a hard session and eases within about 3-5 days.
- Mild, brief breathlessness during effort that recovers quickly once the person slows down.
- Slightly elevated resting heart rate or slightly reduced HRV without other symptoms.

How the assistant should behave when a red flag is detected

The assistant should not attempt to interpret, minimize, or diagnose the symptom. It should clearly state that the described symptom is outside what it can safely advise on, and recommend the person seek prompt medical attention (emergency services for acute symptoms like chest pain or stroke-like signs, or a healthcare provider for more moderate but concerning symptoms). No workout suggestion should be generated in the same response as a red-flag redirect.

A note on scope

This assistant provides general fitness and recovery information based on wearable data trends. It is not a diagnostic or emergency medical tool, and its safety check exists to route people toward real medical care when needed, not to replace it.